

Urdu tinged with Tasawuf forms A Golden Chain between Iran and India

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Urdu is a language, which is widely spoken as mother tongue by twenty three million people in the Indian subcontinent. It is indeed, the official language of the government of Pakistan and the state language of Jammu and Kashmir in India¹. It is one of the major languages of Islamicate society written in Perso-Arabic script and its literature has evolved over the centuries of Muslim rule in the Indian subcontinent that has preserved the best forms of ideas, expressions, and emotions of the people of Iran and India in its rich treasure trove of literature. Indo-Iran contact has played a vital role in the development of Urdu language and literature through the ages. The two most important and concrete examples of this historical and cultural contact is the birth of Urdu language and literature and the appearance of the Taj Mahal on the map of India. As the Taj is considered, “a dream in marble, a poem in stone,”² so is the Hindi language tinged with Persian becomes as sweet as sugar.

گرچه ہندی در عذوبت شکر است
طرز گفتار داری شیرین تر است³

Though the language of Hind is as sweet as sugar,
Yet sweeter is the expression of Dari.

Indo Persian contact began in the eleventh century AD by the advent of the Ghaznavids at Lahore in India. Apart from the kings and conquerors, the Sufis also came to the land of the *Vedas* and *Upanishad* and brought with them the message of love, fraternity, and ethical values of Perso-Islamic culture for the people of the subcontinent. One of the early Sufis who enriched the literary and spiritual life in the Indian subcontinent was Shaikh Fariduddin Masud Ganj-i-Shekar who was a disciple of Khwaja Bakhtiyar Kaki and lived in Pak Patan presently in Pakistan. He

¹ The World's Major Languages; ed. Bernard Comrie; Groom Helm London; 1982; p. 470

² Iran and India through the ages; Firoze C. Davar; Asia Publishing House; Bombay; 1962; p.210

³ Kuliyyat Ashar-i-Farsi-i-Maulana Iqbal Lahori; Introduction, etc. Ahmad Suroosh; Kitab Khane-i-Sanai; Tehran; 1370; p.11

passed away in 1265 and his tomb remained a pilgrimage centre for his disciples in South Asia⁴. He wrote beautiful poems full of ethical values in Perso-Urdu language, which later on came to be known as *rekhta* poems. The poem consists of a mixture of Persian and Urdu expressions in which the Sufi edifies his followers. He asks them to wake up in the morning, which is a time to seek divine blessings. He tells them not to listen to the impulse of sleep that lulls a man to slumber. He insists them to do a good turn in life that alone is the provision of the journey from this world to the next. He exhorts the disciples to listen to his advice implicitly and not to squander away their precious life which they get only once in their lifetime.

وقتِ سحر وقتِ مناجات ہے خیز در آں وقت کہ برکات ہے

نفس مبادا کہ بگو ید ترا خسپ چہ خیزی کہ ابھی رات ہے

با تن تنہا چہ روی زین زمین نیک عمل کن کہ یہی ساتھ ہے

پند شکر گنج بجان گوش کن ضایع مکن عمر کہ ہدہات ہے⁵

Morning is the prayer time; get up at the time which is full of blessings,

Lest the impulse bid you: Sleep, it is night now!

Why do you depart empty handed from this world?

Do a good-turn that alone accompanies you to the next world,

Listen to the advice of Ganj-i-Shekar,

And, Lo! Do not waste your life.

During the later Mughal period, Urdu language and literature became highly distinct and distinguished in forms and expressions and in spite of its Hindustani syntax, it absorbed disproportionate amount of linguistic and literary properties of Persian language and literature. Besides, it profusely borrowed thoughts and ideas from the mint of Persian mysticism. It is said that “poetry without mysticism is prose”. One of the hallmarks of Urdu poetry is Perso-Islamic mysticism or Sufism which is indeed a corner stone of the edifice of the poetry of Ghalib and Iqbal the two most important figures of Urdu literature.

⁴ Sufism in India: An Overview; Naresh; NBT India; 2017; p.31

⁵ Sufi-i- Azam Hazrat Baba Shaikh Farid Ganj-i-Shekar; Hayat Aur Karnameh; Sardar Gurbachan Singh Khalsa; Hyderabad, 1985; p.37

Ghalib and Iqbal are the bilingual poets of Urdu and Persian in India whose poetic *oeuvre* is more in Persian than in Urdu. However, their Urdu poetry reveals a great deal of Persian thoughts and expressions and account for their deep indulgence in and study of the rich literary corpus of Persia from Rudaki to Qaani or QuratulAinTahereh. Ghalib depicts a live scenario of a primary school in one of his prosaic Urdu couplets where he says that he is taking the basic lessons of life, learning by heart, as students learn Persian grammar lessons like *raft*, he went and *bud*, it was, at school.

لیتا ہوں مکتب غم دل میں سبق ہنوز
لیکن یہی کہ رفت گیا اور بود تھا⁶

One of the dominant themes of spiritualism in Persian and Urdu poetry is the theme of *Oneness of God* who is considered as the One and the Only and His divine beauty is celebrated in the best poetic expressions in Persian and Urdu literatures. Mirza Ghalib though in his real life was a practicing poet with all the worldly vices, but by temperament, he was an idle Sufi. His Urdu poetry is highly Persianized in terms of language and literary expressions. Omar Khayyam had treated various worldly themes in his *Rubaiyat* and one of the concepts, which he introduced into his *Rubaiyat*, was the *Oneness of God* or Monotheism. His translator Fitz Gerald has translated a *Rubai* of Khayyam in which it is discussed that though a man does not worship the Almighty and continues to commit sins after sins but pins his hope on Him for divine forgiveness as because he always believes in the Oneness of God.

*The pearls of worship I ne'er strung for Thee
Nor Cleansed my face of sin's foul stain, I see
Hope Thou mayst yet forgive me all, because
I never counted One as two or three⁷*

The Iranians had developed the concept of monotheism and believed that Unity would never beget Plurality⁸. Ghalib has conceived this theme in one of his Urdu Ghazals and broods over a gamut of Sufi themes that goes into the formation and development of human life in our society.

⁶Diwan-i-Ghalib; Shaikh Ghulam Ali & Sons, Tajiran-i- KutubwaMalikan-i- Ilmi Press, Kashmiri Bazar, Lahore; p. 11

⁷ Omar Khayyam; tr. Edward Fitz Gerald; illustrated in Colour by Gilbert James; A&C Black Ltd; London; p.23

⁸Tarikh-i-Tasawuf Allama Mohammad Iqbal; ed. Sabir Kalurwi; Maktaba Al Hasanat; Delhi; 1999; p.36

He confides in us the issues between man and God and refers to the Covenant by which man has pledged his allegiance to Him on the dawn of creation. He says that who can see God the One and the Only; if He were two, then He would be four or one might have seen Him somewhere. And finally Ghalib says about his Sufi temperament:

یہ مسائل تصوف، یہ ترا بیان غالب
تجھے ہم ولی سمجھتے جو نہ بادہ خوار ہوتا⁹

*Your mystical flights Ghalib, Your manner of expressions
We would think of you as a seer, if you were not a wine lover¹⁰*

Iqbal was a poet philosopher of Indo Persian literature and he obtained his Ph.D. on *The Development of Metaphysics in Persia* from the Munich University, Germany on 4th November 1907¹¹. He has composed Urdu poetry in a completely Persian tone and tenor. His Urdu syntax sounds more Persian than Hindi wherein he says:

نہیں منت کش تاب شنیدن داستان میری¹²

In the entire syntax only *nahin* and *meri* are Hindi words and the rest of the wordings are Persian. Iqbal has proclaimed himself a veritable pupil of Rumi and has profusely borrowed spiritual themes and Persian expressions from the works of his master. In his *Asrar-i-Khudi*, he dwells upon the theme of love and a sizeable portion of his Urdu and Indo-Persian poetry is embellished with the theme of love. In *Asrar-i-Khudi*, he says that a man by means of love becomes more immortal, he becomes more alive, more shining, and more luminous:

زنده تر سوزنده تر تابنده تر از محبت میشود پاینده تر¹³

⁹Diwan-i- Ghalib(Nuskha-i- Anjuman) Mirza Asadullah Khan Ghalib; AnjumanTaraqqi-i- Urdu(Hind) New Delhi; p.27

¹⁰ Ghalib Epistemologies and Elegance; AzraRaza& Sara Suleri Goodyear; Penguin Viking; New Delhi; 2009; p.69

¹¹Iqbal: Poet Philosopher of Pakistan; ed. Hafiz Malik; Columbia University Press; 1971; p.19

¹²Kuliyat i Iqbal; Mohammad Iqbal; Educational Book House; Aligarh; p.68

¹³KuliyatAshar-i-Farsi-i-Maulanalqballahori; Introduction, etc. Ahmad Suroosh; KitabKhane-i-Sanai; Tehran; 1370; p.14

The same concept is couched in his Urdu poetry in which he says that the Angels call it a flight when a man reaches the heaven; but man is more alive more enduring and more shining.

زمین سے نوریاں آسماں پرواز کھتے تھے
یہ خاکی زندہ تر پائندہ تر تابندہ تر نکلے¹⁴

Urdu language and literature has borrowed lock, stock and barrel concepts and expressions from Persian language and literature. Persian has sweetened the syntax of Hindi and its Perso-Arabic script has clothed the language in silk and brocade which is soft and colourful. It has made the language sonorous and melodious and its literature refined and sublime.

¹⁴Kuliyat i Iqbal; Mohammad Iqbal; Educational Book House; Aligarh; p.272